# How Much Are People Using Claude for Election Information?*

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July 31, 2026

## Estimating the Effect of Primary Elections on the Rate of Political Claude Conversations

We want to know whether people use AI assistants to research upcoming elections. Individual AI conversations are private and usage data are proprietary, but the Anthropic Economic Index (AEI) now publishes anonymized, aggregated Claude usage at a useful resolution: the share of each U.S. state's conversations assigned to each topic in a hierarchy, by calendar month, for April and May 2026.[1] Our outcome is the share of a state's conversations in the "Politics and public record" topic, the broadest political category, published in both months for 33 states.

The 2026 primary calendar supplies the variation: statewide primaries were spread from March through September, so residents of different states needed election information in different months. Eight states in the panel held their primaries in May (Alabama, Georgia, Idaho, Indiana, Louisiana, Ohio, Oregon, Pennsylvania); 22 states held theirs between June and September and serve as controls. Texas, North Carolina, and Illinois held March primaries and are excluded as already treated. We estimate a difference-in-differences,

$$y_{sm} = \delta\,(\text{May primary}_s \times \text{May}_m) + \alpha_s + \gamma_m + \varepsilon_{sm}, \tag{1}$$

where $y_{sm}$ is the politics-topic share in state $s$ and month $m \in \{\text{April}, \text{May}\}$, with state and month fixed effects and standard errors clustered by state. The identifying assumption

*Claude Fable 5 (Anthropic) wrote the analysis code and most of this memo. I reviewed the code and text after the fact and checked them for accuracy.

[1] Released CC-BY at `https://huggingface.co/datasets/Anthropic/EconomicIndex`, `release_2026_06_26`. Cells with too few conversations to protect privacy are not published, and topic taxonomies are re-estimated in each release, so we use only this release.

is that, absent a primary, May-primary states' conversation topics would have moved like later-primary states'.

## Claude Conversations Shift Toward Politics When a State Holds Its Primary

Holding a primary shifts a state's Claude conversations toward politics. In April, before any of them voted, the eight May-primary states devoted 0.40 percent of conversations to the politics topic; in May, their primary month, 0.50 percent. The 22 later-primary states sat at 0.48 percent in both months (Figure 1a). The shift is broad-based rather than driven by an outlier: seven of the eight treated states move up, with a median change of +0.10 percentage points, while control-state changes straddle zero (Figure 1b).

Table 1 reports the estimates. The primary raises the politics-topic share by 0.10 percentage points (s.e. 0.04)—22 percent of the control-group May mean—and the estimate is similar when June-primary states, where mail voting begins in May, are dropped from the control group (0.09), and in logs (a 27 percent increase, s.e. 9 percent). With 30 states, the design can detect effects of about 0.11 percentage points, so the estimate sits at the edge of detectability: we can rule out effects twice as large but not half as large.

One corroborating pattern: the AEI's narrow "Elections" subtopic is published only where conversation counts clear the privacy floor. It appears in three states in April but eight in May, and the newly published states are disproportionately May-primary states (Oregon, Pennsylvania, Georgia)—election conversations became common enough to publish exactly where and when primaries occurred.

## The Same Shift Appears in Google Searches, About Twice as Large

How does the conversation response compare to the standard measure of public demand for election information? We assemble weekly Google search interest in "primary election" for all fifty states and the District of Columbia from July 2025 through the end of the AEI window, aggregated to calendar months.[2] Like the conversation outcome, the index is a

[2] Search interest measures the term's share of all searches in a state-week, indexed 0–100. Because scripted access to Google Trends is blocked, the series were read off the site's rendered charts in a browser and validated exactly against the one batch the site's own export produced; `original_data/google_trends/readme.txt` documents the collection. Trends normalizes each five-state collection batch to its own maximum, a state-specific scaling absorbed by the state fixed effects under logs.

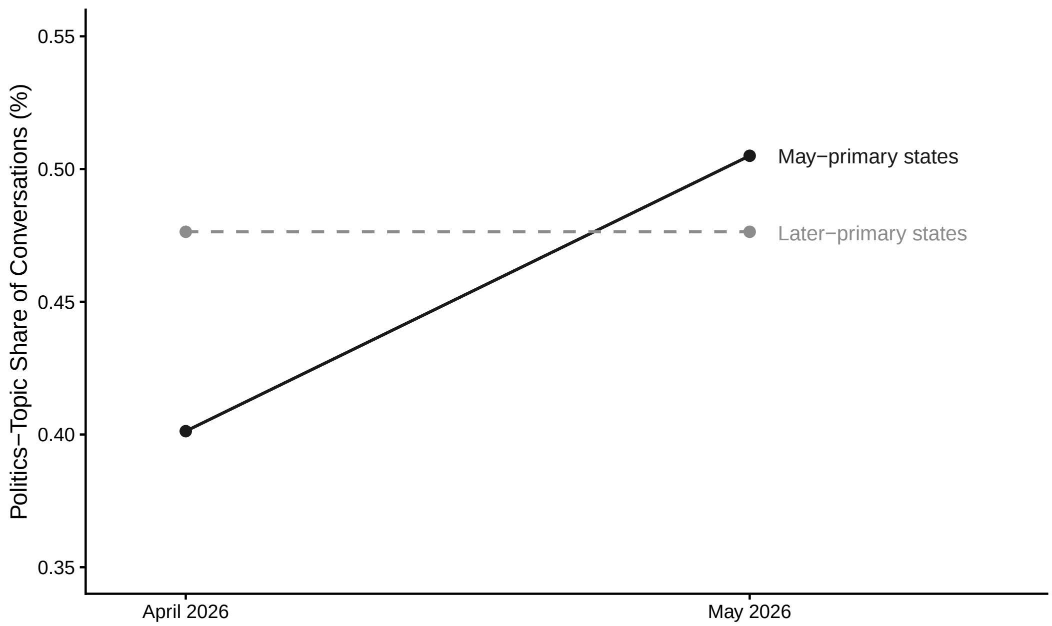
share of activity rather than a volume, and the estimating equation, sample, months, and treatment coding are identical to those behind Table 1; outcomes are in logs so the two responses compare as proportional effects.

Searches respond about twice as strongly. Table 2 reports the comparison: the primary month raises log search interest by 0.49 (s.e. 0.17) in the same 30 states where it raises the log politics-conversation share by 0.24 (s.e. 0.09), and the search estimate is nearly unchanged using all 46 non-March-primary jurisdictions. Figure 2a shows the search analogue of Figure 1a: the two groups track each other for nine months—including common surges at the November 2025 elections and the first primaries in March, national news that the month fixed effects absorb—then separate sharply inside the AEI window.

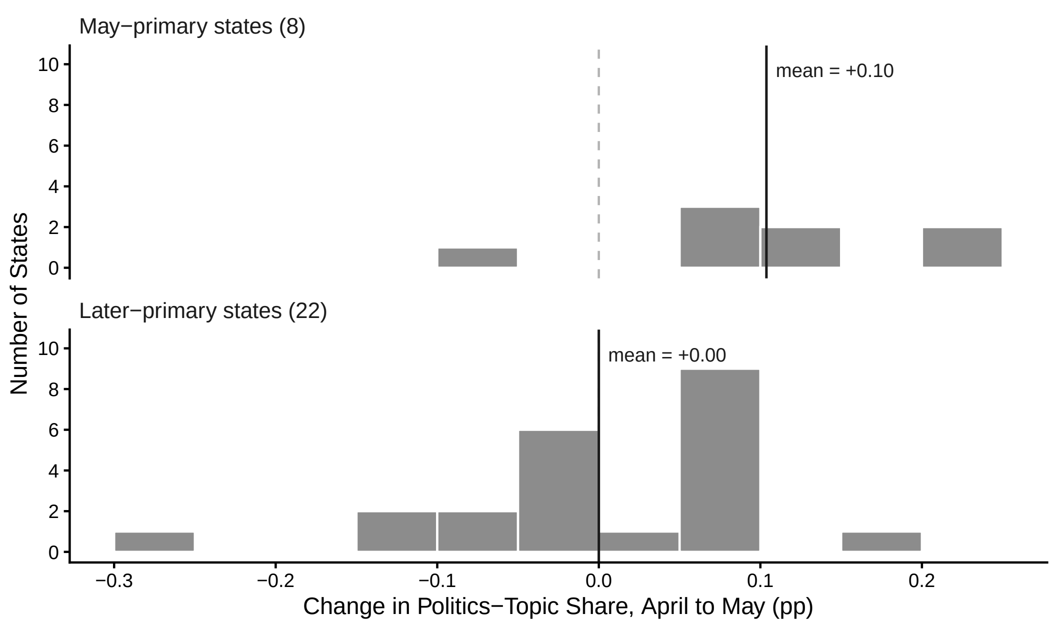
The longer search panel also supports the identification checks the two-month Claude panel cannot. Figure 2b holds out March 2026, the last month before election activity begins in the treated states. Through the 8 preceding months the two groups track each other closely: no individual monthly gap is large, though a joint test of the leads only marginally clears conventional thresholds ($p = 0.061$), so the pre-period is consistent with parallel trends without establishing them decisively. Treated states' searches then rise notably in April—0.63 log points above the control trend, as early voting and campaigning for the May primaries begin—and rise further still in May, to 1.12 log points, roughly double the April-to-May increment that the difference-in-differences uses. This pattern suggests the April-to-May differences in the Claude data probably understate the effect of the election on the rate of political conversation across these months: April is already a partially treated baseline (and control states are themselves lifted in May by national coverage of the big primary days), so the estimates in Table 1 are best read as lower bounds.

## What These Estimates Can and Cannot Tell Us

Four limitations to keep in mind. First, the AEI panel is two months long, so the Claude design is a single pre/post contrast across primary cohorts; the parallel-trends and anticipation checks come from the search panel rather than from the Claude data themselves. Second, the privacy threshold limits the sample to 30 larger states and rules out the narrow "Elections" topic as an outcome; the "Politics and public record" topic includes political conversation beyond election logistics. Third, values are published rounded to two decimals, which adds noise that is meaningful relative to a 0.10-point effect. Fourth, the estimates describe the volume of politics-related conversations, not their content or accuracy.

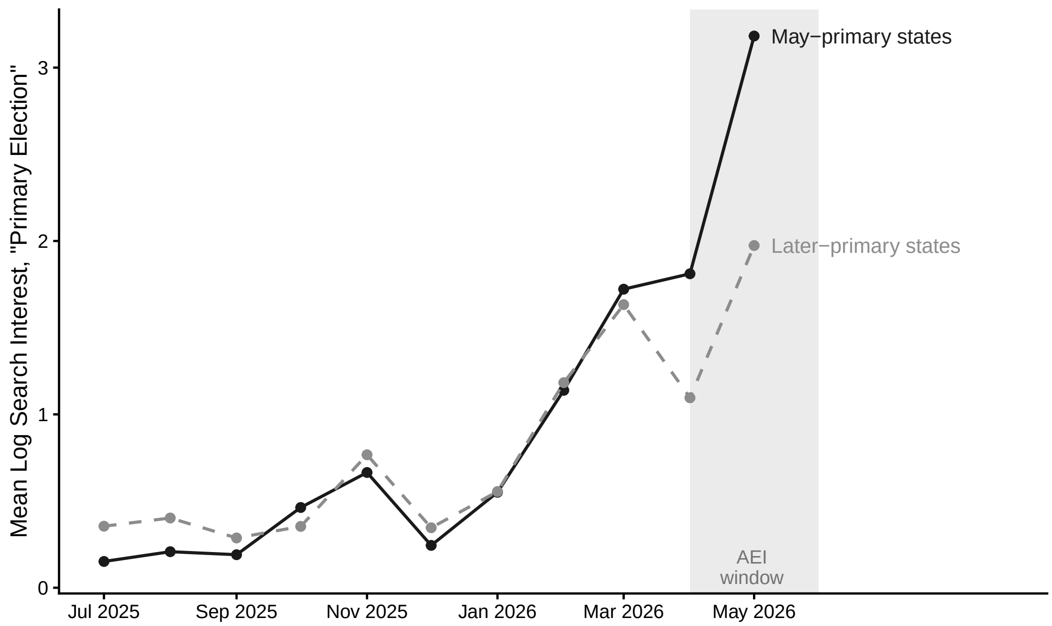



(a) Group means

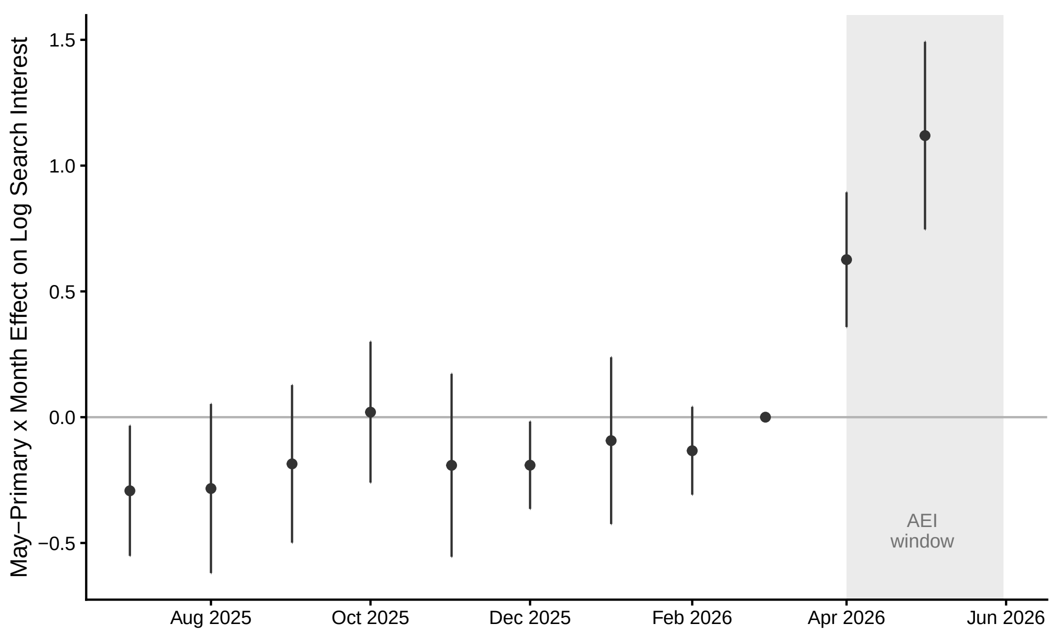



(b) Distribution of state-level changes

Figure 1: **The politics-topic share of Claude conversations rises when a state holds its primary.** Panel (a) plots the mean politics-topic share of conversations in April and May 2026 for the eight states with May 2026 primaries and the 22 states with June-September primaries; March-primary states are excluded. Panel (b) shows each state's April-to-May change, by group, with vertical lines at the group means.




(a) Monthly group means




(b) Event-study estimates, reference month March 2026

Figure 2: **Google searches for "primary election" replicate the design and reveal anticipation.** Panel (a) plots mean log search interest by month for the same May-primary and later-primary state groups as Figure 1; the shaded band is the AEI April–May window. Panel (b) plots coefficients on May-primary-state indicators by month, with state and month fixed effects, relative to March 2026, the last month before election activity begins in the treated states; whiskers are 95 percent confidence intervals clustered by state. The leads are individually small and jointly only marginally distinguishable from zero; the gap opens in April as early voting begins and roughly doubles in May.

Table 1: **Claude Conversations Shift Toward Politics When a State Holds Its Primary.**

| | Politics-Topic Share (%) | | Log Share |
|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Primary × May | 0.10 | 0.09 | 0.24 |
| | (0.04) | (0.04) | (0.09) |
| # States | 30 | 20 | 30 |
| # Treated States | 8 | 8 | 8 |
| # Observations | 60 | 40 | 60 |
| Control May Mean | 0.48 | 0.45 | 0.48 |
| Minimum Detectable Effect | 0.11 | 0.12 | 0.24 |
| State Fixed Effects | Yes | Yes | Yes |
| Month Fixed Effects | Yes | Yes | Yes |
| Excl. June-Primary Controls | No | Yes | No |

*Notes*: Each column reports a difference-in-differences estimate comparing the politics-topic share of Claude conversations in April and May 2026 between states holding a statewide primary in May 2026 and states with later primaries. The outcome in columns 1 and 2 is the percent of a state's conversations assigned to the "Politics and public record" topic in the Anthropic Economic Index; column 3 uses its natural log. Texas, North Carolina, and Illinois, which held March primaries, are excluded. Column 2 further drops control states with June primaries, whose mail voting begins in May. Standard errors clustered by state are in parentheses. The minimum detectable effect is 2.80 times the standard error.

Table 2: **The Primary-Month Shift Is About Twice as Large in Google Searches as in Claude Conversations.**

| | Claude Politics | Google "Primary Election" Searches | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | (1) | (2) | (3) |
| Primary × May | 0.24 | 0.49 | 0.46 |
| | (0.09) | (0.17) | (0.17) |
| # States | 30 | 30 | 46 |
| # Treated States | 8 | 8 | 11 |
| # Observations | 60 | 60 | 92 |
| Minimum Detectable Effect | 0.24 | 0.47 | 0.47 |
| State Fixed Effects | Yes | Yes | Yes |
| Month Fixed Effects | Yes | Yes | Yes |
| AEI 30-State Sample | Yes | Yes | No |

*Notes*: Each column reports the same April-versus-May 2026 difference-in-differences with a log outcome, so estimates are comparable as proportional effects. Column 1 is the log politics-topic share of Claude conversations (as in Table 1, column 3). Columns 2 and 3 are log Google search interest in "primary election," aggregated from weekly state series to calendar months; column 2 uses the same 30 states as column 1, and column 3 uses every jurisdiction except the five March-primary states. Trends indices are normalized within collection batch, a state-specific scaling absorbed by the state fixed effects under the log transformation. Standard errors clustered by state are in parentheses. The minimum detectable effect is 2.80 times the standard error.